Downscript

Installation guide for macOS and Windows · version 0.1.0

Downscript is a Chrome extension that collects the videos of a TikTok profile (and Instagram, Facebook and YouTube pages) and turns each one into a Markdown transcript. Everything runs on your own Mac. Pick the part for your computer (A for macOS, B for Windows). Installation takes about five minutes and has two pieces: the **extension** inside Chrome, and a small local **companion** that runs the transcription tools.

Part A. macOS

1. Before you start

You need	Notes
A Mac with Google Chrome	Signed in to TikTok in Chrome (the downloader reads its cookies).
Python 3	Check with `python3 --version` in Terminal. If missing, macOS offers to install the developer tools.
Homebrew	Used below to install the tools. Get it at `brew.sh` if you don't have it.
About 600 MB of disk space	For the tools and the Whisper speech model.

2. Install the transcription tools

Open **Terminal** and run:

```
brew install yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cpp
```

Then download a Whisper speech model (the "small" model is a good balance of speed and accuracy; English-only users can use `ggml-small.en.bin` instead):

```
mkdir -p ~/Models
curl -L -o ~/Models/ggml-small.bin https://huggingface.co/ggerganov/whisper.cpp/resolv
e/main/ggml-small.bin
```

Find where Homebrew put each tool. You will need these paths in step 5:

```
which yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cli
```

> **Apple Silicon Macs (M1 and newer):** Homebrew installs to `/opt/homebrew/bin/`, while Downscript's defaults point to `/usr/local/bin/`. This is expected. Just enter the paths printed by the command above in the settings page (step 5).

3. Unzip and load the extension

1. Unzip **downscript.zip**. Move the resulting `downscript` folder somewhere permanent, for example your Documents folder. **Do not move it afterwards** without re-running the installer in step 4.
2. In Chrome, open `chrome://extensions` and switch on **Developer mode** (top right).
3. Click **Load unpacked** and select the `downscript/extension` folder.
4. Confirm that the extension's ID is `hkmbgalpmjbphbjbldhghodghfmcbafi`. This ID is fixed, so it should match on every machine.
5. Click the puzzle-piece icon in the Chrome toolbar and pin **Downscript** so it is easy to reach.

4. Install the companion

The companion is the small program Chrome talks to. In Terminal, go into the unzipped folder (adjust the path if you placed it elsewhere):

```
cd ~/Documents/downscript/companion
python3 -m venv .venv
.venv/bin/pip install -r requirements.txt
chmod +x install.sh host.py
./install.sh
```

The `.venv` step installs `yt-dlp` together with `curl_cffi`, which TikTok downloads need in order to look like a normal browser. Without it, TikTok answers with "403 Forbidden" errors.

The installer registers the companion with Chrome and prints the folder paths it used. If Chrome showed a different extension ID in step 3, run `./install.sh <the-id>` instead.

5. Check the setup

1. Click the Downscript icon, then the gear icon to open **Settings**.
2. Enter the paths from step 2 for *yt-dlp*, *ffmpeg* and *whisper-cli*, and the path of your model (for example `~/Models/ggml-small.bin`). Choose where transcripts are saved (default: your Downloads folder) and your browser for cookies (default: Chrome). Save.
3. Press **Check setup**. Wait for every row to turn green.

Part B. Windows 10 and 11

> **Windows support is new.** macOS is the most tested environment. If a step does not work for you, write to oren@techspirit.co.il and include the text of any error.

1. Before you start

You need	Notes
Windows 10 or 11 with Google Chrome	Signed in to TikTok in Chrome.
Python 3	Install from `python.org/downloads` and tick **Add python.exe to PATH** on the first screen (or run `winget install Python.Python.3.12`). Check with `py -3 --version`.
About 600 MB of disk space	For the tools and the Whisper speech model.

Open **PowerShell** from the Start menu for all commands in this part. Do not run it as administrator.

2. Install the transcription tools

ffmpeg (converts audio):

```
winget install Gyan.FFmpeg
```

whisper.cpp (the transcription program): on GitHub, open the whisper.cpp "Releases" page (`github.com/ggml-org/whisper.cpp/releases`), download the Windows zip for 64-bit PCs (`whisper-bin-x64.zip`), and unzip it to a permanent folder such as `C:\Tools\whisper`. Inside it, find `whisper-cli.exe` and note its full path.

A Whisper model (the "small" model is a good balance of speed and accuracy):

```
mkdir $HOME\Models
curl.exe -L -o $HOME\Models\ggml-small.bin https://huggingface.co/ggerganov/whisper.cpp/resolve/main/ggml-small.bin
```

Close and reopen PowerShell, then find the full path of ffmpeg. You will need it in step 5:

```
where.exe ffmpeg
```

You do not need to install yt-dlp yourself. Step 4 installs it inside the companion's own environment.

3. Unzip and load the extension

1. Right-click **downscript.zip** and choose **Extract All**. Move the resulting `downscript` folder somewhere permanent, for example your Documents folder. **Do not move it afterwards** without re-running the installer in step 4.
2. In Chrome, open `chrome://extensions` and switch on **Developer mode** (top right).

3. Click **Load unpacked** and select the `downscript\extension` folder.
4. Confirm that the extension's ID is `hkmbgalpmjbphbjbldhghodghfmcbafi`, and pin the Downscript icon in the Chrome toolbar.

4. Install the companion

In PowerShell, go into the unzipped folder (adjust the path if you placed it elsewhere) and run:

```
cd $HOME\Documents\downscript\companion
py -3 -m venv .venv
.\.venv\Scripts\pip install -r requirements.txt
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\install.ps1
```

The `.venv` step installs `yt-dlp` together with `curl_cffi`, which TikTok downloads need. The installer registers the companion with Chrome (it writes one entry under `HKEY_CURRENT_USER`, so no administrator rights are needed). If Chrome showed a different extension ID, add `-ExtensionId <the-id>` to the last command.

5. Check the setup

1. Click the Downscript icon, then the gear icon to open **Settings**.
2. Paste the **full paths** of `ffmpeg.exe` (from `where.exe`) and `whisper-cli.exe`, and the path of the model (for example `C:\Users\you\Models\ggml-small.bin`). Leave the yt-dlp field as it is, because the companion's own copy is used automatically. Save.
3. Press **Check setup** and wait for every row to turn green.

> **Cookies on Windows:** Chrome protects its cookies more strictly on Windows, so yt-dlp sometimes cannot read them. If you see cookie errors, choose **Edge** or **Firefox** in the "Cookies from browser" setting (signed in to TikTok there), or close Chrome completely and try again.

Using Downscript

1. In Chrome, open a TikTok profile such as `https://www.tiktok.com/@username` (or an Instagram profile, a Facebook Reels page, or a YouTube playlist).
2. Click the Downscript icon, or press `Cmd + Shift + E`.
3. Press **Start Extraction**. The popup shows discovery and transcription progress.
4. Transcripts are saved as Markdown files, one per video, in:

   ```
   ~/Downloads/<account name>/transcripts/tiktok/transcript_<id>_<title>.md
   ```

5. Running the same profile again skips videos that are already done, and **Cancel** can be resumed later.

> Downloads are paced on purpose. Large profiles take a while, and the extension stops and tells you if a platform starts blocking requests. If that happens, wait a few minutes and run it again.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
"Check setup" shows a red row	The path in Settings is wrong. Re-run `which yt-dlp ffmpeg whisper-cli` and paste the exact paths. For the model, check the file exists in `~/Models`.
Chrome cannot reach the companion ("native host not found")	Run `./install.sh` again from the `companion` folder, then reload the extension in `chrome://extensions`. If the extension ID differs from the one in the load step, pass it to the installer.
You moved the `downscript` folder	The installer remembers the folder's location. Run the installer again from the new location.
Downloads fail with 403 on TikTok	Make sure the "install the companion" step was completed (`.venv` with `curl_cffi`) and that you are signed in to TikTok in Chrome. A short wait often helps, because the block is temporary.
Permission errors reading browser cookies (macOS)	Open System Settings > Privacy & Security > Full Disk Access and allow your Terminal app and Google Chrome, then try again.
Windows: `py` is not recognized	Python is not installed or not on PATH. Reinstall it from python.org with "Add python.exe to PATH" ticked, then open a new PowerShell window.
Windows: "running scripts is disabled"	Use the exact command from step 4, which includes `-ExecutionPolicy Bypass` for this one run.
"Permission denied" when running a script (macOS)	Run `chmod +x install.sh host.py` in the `companion` folder.

Updating and removing

- **Update:** replace the `downscript` folder with the new version, rebuild the `.venv`, run the installer again (`./install.sh` on macOS, `install.ps1` on Windows), and click Reload on the extension in `chrome://extensions`.
- **Remove:** click *Remove* on the extension in `chrome://extensions`, delete the `downscript` folder, and on macOS delete the file `~/Library/Application Support/Google/Chrome/NativeMessagingHosts/com.downscript.companion.json`; on Windows run `Remove-Item "HKCU:\Software\Google\Chrome\NativeMessagingHosts\com.downscript.companion"` in PowerShell.
